

DECODED EXPLAINED

30th July, 2026

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

India's theatre reform needs a readiness framework

India's theatre-isation is nearing completion. The United States, the United Kingdom, and China have already made this shift: modern conflict favours integrated structures over single-service models. India is now moving in the same direction. The transition, however, may temporarily reduce operational readiness. The key question is what will be lost, how much, and for how long before capability is restored.

Transforming a single-service structure that has stood for seven decades is difficult. The merger of 17 single-service commands into three integrated theatres carries three real risks.

First, the knowledge gap at the top. A theatre commander will command forces from three services, at least two of which he has not spent decades honing. Staff can advise, but it cannot replace the instincts built over a career – knowing how quickly a mechanised brigade mobilises or a fighter squadron scrambles. In a fast-paced conflict such as Operation Sindoor (2025), that gap becomes critical when domain expertise matters most.

Second, each service has unique values and cultures – merging them is difficult, which will show up sharpest around careers and rank. A joint force worried about career progression or rank-equivalence – hurting morale and motivation – can dampen active combat.

Third, slower decision-making. Adding the Vice Chief of Defence Staff (VCDS), alongside the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS), adds a layer between the theatre commanders and the Raksha Mantri – one more link between order and action. Theatre commanders are to report directly to the Raksha Mantri once fighting starts. But an untested structure cannot suddenly switch on under fire, and peacetime habits of routing through the VCDS would be hard to break when speed matters most.

None of this argues against theatre commands; the reform must proceed. All three hit short-term



Harinder Singh

Former Director,
Operational Logistics,
at the Army
Headquarters

Modernising
military
structures while
maintaining
readiness
remains the
key challenge

readiness first, with no time to recover once fighting starts. The risk compounds; gaps in data links, jointness and logistics rarely surface until a crisis forces the question. India's Air Force chief has argued that coordination may serve better than forcing fusion too fast. The next question is how much this costs, and for how long.

How much and for how long

Here is a rough but useful distinction. First, the nature of change. Reforms touching weapon-platforms show results within months; those touching structures such as the Andaman and Nicobar Command took over a decade. Theatre-isation is the second category – who commands what, and how fast the three services fuse as one fighting system – and that costs readiness.

Second, the scale of the delay. The current plan may take two to three years, while full transition could take a decade or more. China created theatre commands in two years and the U.S. in 10; India has spent 25 years debating the move. The real challenge is not money or hardware, but mindsets – hierarchy, authority, and command structures. Even the U.K. restructured its joint command twice since 2012. For India, the risk is reduced readiness along the borders during transition.

Third, the timing. India faces pressure on two fronts – an unresolved boundary with China, a festering rivalry with Pakistan. A long war gives theatre-isation time to mature; a short one runs on whatever readiness is on hand. China raised five theatre commands in 2016; the one facing India was tested at Doklam in 2017, and in 2020. The Goldwater-Nichols Act (1986), a success after its first test in Panama, spent a decade absorbing its readiness costs – diluted expertise, command friction.

Indian defence planning just treats reform as self-executing: approve the structure, allocate

roles, and assume readiness follows. Beijing shows otherwise: it took two years to raise five theatre commands.

The gap is partly procedural and partly semantic. India still speaks of “defence preparedness”; modern militaries focus on “military readiness” – staying ready, always. India has yet to develop a military readiness framework. It needs one now, along with four key reforms.

First, the metrics – a public statement of what the joint force must be ready to fight is essential. Naming these readiness risks matters. A “two-front” threat can quietly become “two-and-a-half” if left unaddressed. No one in India has said this openly.

Second, the standards that measure force structures against operational demands. India measures inputs – money, manpower, machines, and material (4Ms) – rather than actual military capability. A readiness standard needs three elements: unit-level readiness, force readiness, and sustainability with surge capacity. The transition window will not wait.

Third, India needs mechanisms that compel policymakers to notice and act. The U.S. created a Readiness Oversight Council in the 1990s. India needs a similar structure: a Defence Readiness Council at the ministry level, a Military Readiness Committee under the CDS, and sub-committees within each service and theatre command.

Fourth, hedge the transition itself. Keep a reserve force outside the new structure so short wars are not fought entirely on untested ground. Diplomacy with China and Pakistan may not resolve long-standing disputes, but it can buy the time theatre-isation requires. Neither guarantees peace, but both create valuable time.

Theatre-isation is not the problem, but assuming it comes at no cost is. Readiness is what is at stake, and war does not wait for the transition to finish.

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

The Indian Army came into existence in its present form on 26 January 1950, coinciding with the commencement of the Constitution and India's transition into a Republic.

The origins of the Indian Army can be traced to 1 April 1895, when the British Indian Army was formally established through the unification of the Presidency Armies.

The Indian Army has an active strength of approximately 12.37 lakh personnel, making it the world's largest voluntary (all-volunteer) army and the second-largest standing army after China.

In addition to its active personnel, the Indian Army has a reserve strength of approximately 9.6 lakh personnel.

The Army Headquarters is located at the Integrated Headquarters of the Ministry of Defence (Army), New Delhi.

The official motto of the Indian Army is "Seva Paramo Dharma", meaning "Service Before Self."

The official quick march of the Indian Army is "Kadam Kadam Badhaye Ja," while the official slow march is "Samman Guard" (The Guard of Honour).

Army Day is celebrated every year on 15 January to commemorate General (later Field Marshal) K. M. Cariappa taking over as the first Indian Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army from General Sir Francis Butcher on 15 January 1949.

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

1. Commissioned Officers (Highest to Lowest)

Field Marshal (Five-star honorary rank) > General > Lieutenant General > Major General > Brigadier > Colonel > Lieutenant Colonel > Major > Captain > Lieutenant

2. Junior Commissioned Officers (JCOs)

Subedar Major (Highest JCO rank) > Subedar > Naib Subedar

3. Non-Commissioned Officers (NCOs)

Havildar > Naik > Lance Naik

4. Other Ranks (ORs)

Sepoy

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

Level	Indian Army	Indian Navy	Indian Air Force
1	Lieutenant	Sub Lieutenant	Flying Officer
2	Captain	Lieutenant	Flight Lieutenant
3	Major	Lieutenant Commander	Squadron Leader
4	Lieutenant Colonel	Commander	Wing Commander
5	Colonel	Captain	Group Captain
6	Brigadier	Commodore	Air Commodore
7	Major General	Rear Admiral	Air Vice Marshal
8	Lieutenant General	Vice Admiral	Air Marshal
9	General (Chief of Army Staff)	Admiral (Chief of Naval Staff)	Air Chief Marshal (Chief of Air Staff)

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework



<u>Command</u>	<u>Headquarters</u>	<u>Primary Responsibility</u>
Northern Command	Udhampur, Jammu & Kashmir	J&K, Ladakh, Pakistan & China borders
Western Command	Chandimandir, Haryana	Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, parts of J&K
South Western Command	Jaipur, Rajasthan	Rajasthan & Gujarat front with Pakistan
Southern Command	Pune, Maharashtra	Peninsular India & maritime support
Eastern Command	Kolkata, West Bengal	Northeast, China, Myanmar & Bangladesh borders
Central Command	Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh	Central India, Uttarakhand & reserve role
Army Training Command (ARTRAC)	Shimla, Himachal Pradesh	Training, doctrine and modernization

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework



Each command consists of several corps, which are field formations responsible for specific operational areas. A corps is commanded by a Lieutenant General.

Types of Corps:

- **Strike Corps : Offensive operations**
- **Holding Corps : Defensive operations**
- **Mixed Corps : Combination of both roles**

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

Corps	Headquarters
I Corps	Mathura, Uttar Pradesh
II Corps	Ambala, Haryana
III Corps	Dimapur, Nagaland
IV Corps	Tezpur, Assam
IX Corps	Yol, Himachal Pradesh
X Corps	Bathinda, Punjab
XI Corps	Jalandhar, Punjab
XII Corps	Jodhpur, Rajasthan
XIV Corps	Leh, Ladakh (UT)
XV Corps	Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir (UT)
XVI Corps	Nagrota, Jammu & Kashmir (UT)
XVII Corps	Panagarh, West Bengal
XXI Corps	Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh
XXXIII Corps	Sukna, West Bengal

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework



Divisions : A corps is composed of multiple divisions, each commanded by a Major General. The Indian Army divisions and units include different types like infantry, armored, mountain, and artillery divisions, along with specialized regiments.

Divisions are subdivided into brigades, which are commanded by a Brigadier. A brigade typically consists of three to four battalions and supporting elements.

A brigade is composed of battalions, the basic fighting units of the Army. A battalion is commanded by a Lieutenant Colonel and comprises approximately 800 to 1,000 soldiers.

Battalions are divided into companies, each commanded by a Major or a Captain. A company consists of around 120 soldiers.

Companies are further divided into platoons and sections. A platoon is led by a Lieutenant and consists of around 30 soldiers. A section, the smallest unit, is led by a non-commissioned officer and comprises 10 soldiers.

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Operational Commands of Indian Airforce

The IAF's operational commands are geographically distributed across India, each tasked with overseeing operations within their respective areas. There are five operational commands:

Command Name

Western Air Command

Eastern Air Command

Central Air Command

Southern Air Command

South Western Air Command

Headquarters

New Delhi

Shillong

Prayagraj

Thiruvananthapuram

Gandhinagar

Command Name

Training Command

Maintenance Command

Headquarters

Bangalore

Nagpur

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

● The Transition

- India's theatre-isation is nearing completion; the US, UK, and China have already shifted to integrated theatre command structures, as modern conflict favours integrated structures over single-service models
- Transforming a single-service structure that has stood for seven decades is difficult; the merger of 17 single-service commands into three integrated theatres carries three real risks

● Three Real Risks

- **First, the knowledge gap at the top:** a theatre commander will command forces from three services, at least two of which he has not spent decades honing; in a fast-paced conflict like Operation Sindoor (2025), that gap becomes critical when domain expertise matters most
- **Second, each service has unique values and cultures;** merging them is difficult and will show up sharpest around careers and rank, and a joint force worried about career progression can dampen active combat motivation
- **Third, slower decision-making: adding the Vice Chief of Defence Staff alongside the Chief of Defence Staff** adds a layer between theatre commanders and the Raksha Mantri, and an untested structure cannot suddenly switch on under fire

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

An ITC is a unified structure where assets from the Army, Navy, and Air Force operate under a single commander for a specific geographical area. This ensures better coordination, faster decision-making, and improved combat effectiveness.

The Kargil Review Committee, 1999 recommended creation of integrated theatre commands and Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) to improve joint operations and address coordination failures during the Kargil War. The Shekatkar Committee, 2016 proposed three integrated theatre commands (Western, Northern, and Southern) to enhance tri-service synergy and resource efficiency.

Inter-Services Organisation (Command, Control, and Discipline) Act 2023 empowers theatre commanders with disciplinary control over all three services and promotes jointness through cross-postings.

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

The Indian Navy operates three principal commands: the Western Naval Command in Mumbai, the Eastern Naval Command in Visakhapatnam, and the Southern Naval Command in Kochi

The Andaman and Nicobar Command (ANC) is the first and only integrated theatre command in India with headquarters at Port Blair and setup in October 2001.

The SFC, sometimes called Strategic Nuclear Command, forms part of India's Nuclear Command Authority (NCA), which is responsible for command-and-control decisions regarding India's nuclear weapons programme.

SFC is responsible for the management and administration of the country's tactical and strategic nuclear weapons stockpile.

It is the responsibility of the SFC to operationalize the orders of the NCA

SFC is also a tri-forces command

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

UPSC Prelims 2026 Question:

Which one of the following pairs is *not* correctly matched?

(Indian Army Corps) (Headquarters)

1. 3 Corps : Dimapur

2. 4 Corps : Tezpur

3. 14 Corps : Leh

4. 33 Corps : Srinagar

India's Theatre Reform Needs a Readiness Framework

UPSC Prelims 2024 Question:

Which of the following is/are correctly matched in terms of equivalent rank in the three services of Indian defence forces?

	<i>Army</i>	<i>Airforce</i>	<i>Navy</i>
1.	Brigadier	Air Commodore	Commander
2.	Major General	Air Vice Marshal	Vice Admiral
3.	Major	Squadron Leader	Lieutenant Commander
4.	Lieutenant Colonel	Group Captain	Captain

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

1. 1 and 4

2. 1 and 3

3. 2, 3 and 4

4. 3 only

Private R&D Spends Cross Government's in FY24

Private R&D spends cross govt.'s in FY24

A level last seen in 2009-10, official data reveal a structural shift: private industry accounted for 45.5% of national R&D spending in 2021-22, rising further to 51.8% in 2023-24, the first time businesses have contributed more to India's research effort than all levels of government combined

Jacob P Koshy
NEW DELHI

India's spending on research and development (R&D) surged to 0.83% of GDP in 2021-22, the first time that the country crossed the 0.8% threshold – a level last seen in 2009-10, according to newly disclosed government data.

The figures also reveal a structural shift in India's innovation landscape: private industry accounted for 45.5% of national R&D spending in 2021-22, rising further to 51.8% in 2023-24, the first time businesses have contributed more to India's research effort than all levels of government combined.

The figures were disclosed by the Department of Science and Technology (DST) in response to a Lok Sabha question on Wednesday. They form part of the latest Research & Development Statistics 2025-26,

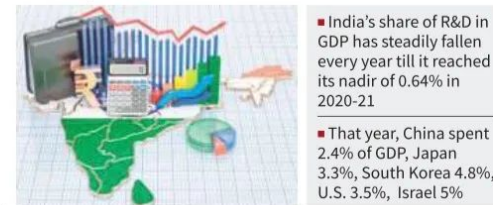
although the full statistical report itself has not yet been publicly released.

The numbers are significant because India, despite possessing one of the world's largest scientific workforces and ranking among the top countries in scientific publications, has long spent a much smaller share of its economy on research than major scientific powers. The share of R&D in GDP – long considered a bellwether of progress – has, in the case of India, steadily fallen every year till it reached its nadir of 0.64% in 2020-21.

That year China spent 2.4% of GDP, Japan 3.3%, South Korea 4.8%, United States 3.5% and around 5% in Israel. Successive governments have also repeatedly argued that India's innovation ecosystem is constrained because industry contributes a much smaller share of national R&D spending than in advanced economies, where

Science wins

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business routinely accounts for over 70% of research expenditure.

DST compiles India's official R&D statistics through its National Science and Technology Management Information System (NSTMIS), which has conducted national science surveys since 1973 using UNESCO and OECD definitions. The surveys gather expenditure data from central and state government agencies, universities, public sector enterprises and private

industry. The 2022-23 edition explicitly stated that its coverage had been expanded to include multinational companies and enterprises outside the Department of Scientific and Industrial Research's recognition scheme. There were 2,397 DSIR-recognised in-house R&D centres as of December 2022. Until Wednesday's parliamentary reply, the latest publicly available DST publication was the 2022-23 edition, released in 2023, which contained

data only up to 2020-21. The parliamentary reply is therefore the first official disclosure of India's R&D expenditure for 2021-22, 2022-23 and 2023-24, even though the corresponding statistical reports have yet to be published.

The fresh data point to an abrupt discontinuity. Gross Expenditure on Research and Development (GERD) fell from ₹1.33 lakh crore in 2019-20 to ₹1.27 lakh crore in 2020-21 (a COVID-year slump), before jumping 53% to ₹1.95 lakh crore in 2021-22. It subsequently rose to ₹2.13 lakh crore in 2022-23 and ₹2.45 lakh crore in 2023-24.

However, budget documents from the period do not suggest a commensurate surge in government science spending. Union allocations to the Department of Science and Technology, Department of Biotechnology, Department of Atomic Energy, ISRO and other major science agen-

cies rose only incrementally across these years, making it unlikely that the increase was driven solely by public expenditure.

The sharp rise in GERD coincided with a dramatic increase in the private sector industry's contribution to India's research spending. Private industry accounted for 38.5% of GERD in 2017-18, 37.7% in 2018-19, 33.8% in 2019-20 and 36.4% in 2020-21, before jumping to 45.5% in 2021-22, 48.0% in 2022-23 and 51.8% in 2023-24 – the first time private industry has contributed more than half of India's total R&D expenditure. In absolute terms, Industry R&D spending increased from about ₹43,800 crore in 2017-18 and ₹46,700 crore in 2018-19 to ₹44,800 crore in 2019-20 and ₹46,400 crore in 2020-21, before almost doubling to ₹88,600 crore in 2021-22 and rising further to ₹126,800 crore in 2023-24.

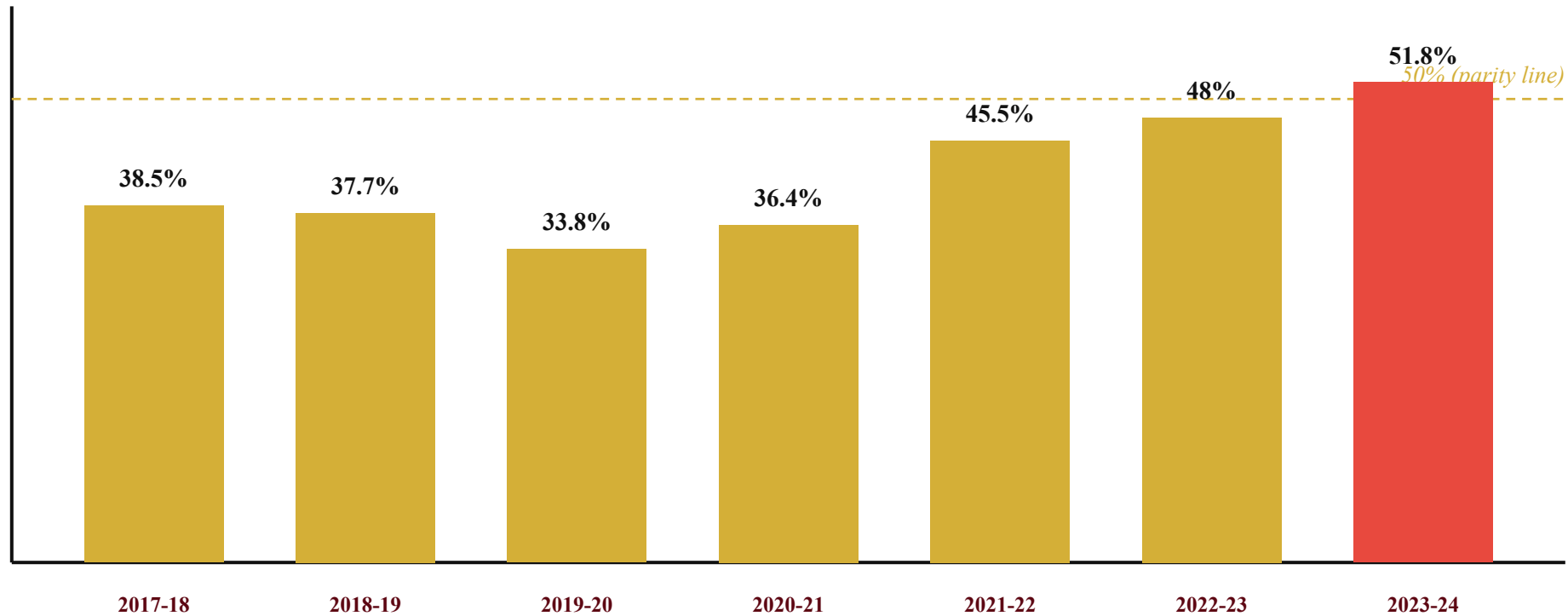
Private R&D Spends Cross Government's in FY24

● The Structural Shift

- India's spending on R&D surged to 0.83% of GDP in 2021-22, the first time the country crossed the 0.8% threshold, a level last seen in 2009-10, according to newly disclosed government data
- The figures reveal a structural shift: private industry accounted for 45.5% of national R&D spending in 2021-22, rising further to 51.8% in 2023-24, the first time businesses have contributed more to India's research effort than all levels of government combined
- The figures were disclosed by the Department of Science and Technology in response to a Lok Sabha question, forming part of the latest Research & Development Statistics 2025-26, though the full statistical report has not yet been publicly released

Private R&D Spends Cross Government's in FY24

Private Industry Overtakes Government in India's R&D Spending



Private industry's share of India's Gross Expenditure on R&D (GERD) crossed 50% for the first time in 2023-24 — a level last matched by government spending in 2009-10.

IRDAI Ushers in Reforms to Revamp Insurance Sector

IRDAI ushers in reforms to revamp insurance sector

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 29

THE INSURANCE Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has introduced a set of reforms aimed at modernising the insurance sector, strengthening governance and accelerating insurance penetration across the country.

The measures span regulatory, supervisory and developmental areas.

The measures aim to support the implementation of the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Act, 2025 (SBSR Act), the regulator said.

The reforms were approved at the IRDAI board meeting on Tuesday and are designed to provide insurers with greater operational flexibility, facilitate capital formation, improve governance standards and reinforce policyholder protection while enhancing ease of doing business across the insurance ecosystem.

Among the key decisions was the approval of amendments to the IRDAI (Actuarial, Finance and Investment Functions of Insurers) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, and the IRDAI (Registration, Capital Structure, Transfer of Shares and Amalgamation of Insurers) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026.

• REFORM PUSH

A KEY feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance

THE REFORMS are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests

THE REVISED framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act

Policyholder protection

According to IRDAI, the changes will provide insurers with "greater operational and financial flexibility through liberalised investment norms, a facilitative framework for capital infusion and corporate restructuring, and streamlined provisions relating to transfer of shares and amalgamations, while strengthening actuarial oversight and financial governance." The regulator said the reforms are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compro-



and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards

mising policyholder interests.

A major policyholder-centric initiative approved by the regulator is the IRDAI (Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund) Regulations, 2026, which operationalise the Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) established under Section 16A of the IRDA Act, 1999, as introduced through the SBSR Act.

According to IRDAI, the PEPF establishes "a dedicated institutional mechanism to promote insurance awareness and literacy, strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms, leverage technology to improve policyholder services,

facilitate the tracing and recovery of unclaimed insurance amounts, and support other initiatives aimed at empowering and safeguarding policyholders."

The intermediaries

In another move to strengthen accountability in insurance distribution, the regulator has approved amendments to the regulations governing insurance intermediaries.

A key feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance. "The requirement enhances accountability and traceability across the insurance distribution process, strengthens regulatory oversight and promotes greater transparency for policyholders," IRDAI said. The amendments also introduce perpetual registration for intermediaries through an annual fee regime, replacing periodic renewals. The revised framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards, the regulator said.

FULL REPORT ON
www.indianexpress.com

IRDAI Ushers in Reforms to Revamp Insurance Sector

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) was established following the recommendations of the Malhotra Committee (1994), which critically examined the need for structural reforms in the insurance sector.

It acts as an autonomous authority under the Ministry of Finance, Government of India.

Head Office: Hyderabad

Entities regulated by IRDAI:

Life Insurance Companies: Both public and private sector companies

General Insurance Companies: Both public and private sector companies. Among them, there are some standalone health insurance companies which offer health insurance policies.

Reinsurance Companies

Agency Channel

Intermediaries, which include the following:

Corporate Agents

Brokers

Third-party Administrators

Surveyors and Loss Assessors.

IRDAI Ushers in Reforms to Revamp Insurance Sector

QUESTION

GS Hard Economy Prelims 2026

With reference to different Committees in India, consider the following details :

Sl. No.	Committee	Objective	Organization under which it was formed
1.	R.N. Malhotra Committee	Comprehensive reforms of Insurance sector in India	Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India
2.	L.C. Gupta Committee	Preparing a roadmap for the introduction of derivatives trading in India	Securities and Exchange Board of India
3.	Urjit R. Patel Committee	Preparing a roadmap for reforming bank lending to the Housing sector	Reserve Bank of India
4.	Y.H. Malegam Committee	Preparing a roadmap for reforms in Microfinance sector in India	Reserve Bank of India

In which of the above rows are all the details correctly matched ?

[Select an option to attempt](#)

A 2 only

B 2 and 3

C 1, 3 and 4

D 2 and 4

Thank You